

encourage earning more, that method can take time. On the other hand, the quickest way to free up income is by decreasing expenses. We frugal people do love this option.

But there is a third option. A radical middle option, if you will. One where we can keep both our income and spending amounts the same (assuming we're not outspending what we earn) and just shift what we're spending on. Take out the impulse and mindless purchases and replace them with more values-aligned purchases. This could mean ordering takeout less and more weekend getaways, or fewer subscriptions and more retirement investing, or no new upgrades and more debt freedom. Essentially, we're fleshing out values-based spending.

While the first two methods for freeing up money focus on numbers, values-based spending focuses on purchasing decisions and the needs behind them. Earning more and buying less looks at *how much* we purchase, whereas values-based spending looks at *what* we purchase. In the real world, we do need all three: earning more, buying less, and making mindful spending decisions. One is not more important than the others—they're all important in varying measures, in different seasons. But because so many other books focus on the numbers, we're going to keep focusing on the purchases and the ways our shifts in this third category also help us get the things we really want.

We didn't start with the math, or by making budgets (although we *will* get to that). Not because those things aren't important, but because so often when we try to take action without having a strong mental foundation backing up that action, it inevitably doesn't go as planned. And we can feel like the failure. But the failure isn't you, it's the order in which money concerns are tackled that's to blame. The reason starting with a budget or simply slicing up your credit cards isn't a long-term solution to a spending problem is because they aren't tethered to anything. Budgets manage the "how much" and beginning with math problems ignores the context of the equation. When we don't understand what's going on behind the numbers on the credit card statements, we're less likely to value them. Because we rarely value what we don't understand. It's why taking time to practice curiosity and learn what you value is so important. It's also why you need to start by understanding your past actions before diving into future action.

With clear eyes, awareness of what you care about, non-shaming questions of curiosity, and permission to not get it perfect, you're ready to